

Narcissistic Abuse and Toxic Relationships

Know the signs and what Scripture says

Toxic is unhealthy patterns on both sides. Abusive is one person using fear, control, and punishment to get their way. Most people do not recognize what they are living in until they see it written out plainly. That is what this is for. Read it slowly. Read it twice if you need to. Nothing here is written to condemn anyone, and nothing here requires you to make a decision today. It is written so you can name what is happening, because you cannot heal from something you are still calling by the wrong name.

YHWH never called you to live afraid in your own home. Yahshua came to restore the very things this steals. Identity. Dignity. Peace. Your voice.

NAMING IT

1. Toxic or Abusive

These two words get used as though they mean the same thing, and confusing them keeps people stuck for years.

Toxic is two people caught in unhealthy patterns. Both are contributing something. Both are wounded. Both can grow, if both are willing to look in the mirror. Toxic can be worked on together.

Abusive is one person using fear, control, and punishment to get their way. It is not a pattern between two people. It is a system one person is running on another. Abuse is not a communication problem, and it will not be fixed by trying harder, praying louder, keeping a cleaner house, or being sweeter. You have already tried all of that. It did not work because it was never about you.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS

Answer these honestly, even if you have never said the answer out loud.

- 1. Do you feel afraid?** Not afraid of losing them. Afraid of them. If your body braces when you hear their car pull in, your body already knows something your mouth has not admitted yet.
- 2. Do you walk on eggshells?** You rehearse how to say things. You time your words around their mood. That is not being considerate. That is managing a threat.
- 3. Do you change your behavior to avoid their anger?** The friend you stopped seeing. The subject you stopped raising. Each one was traded for a little peace, and the price kept going up.
- 4. Do you feel smaller every year?** Think about who you were when you met them. Abuse rarely takes everything at once. It takes a piece at a time, slow enough that you keep explaining it away.

If you answered yes to these, that is not a rough patch and it is not a season. Naming it is not betrayal. It is the first honest thing you may have done in a long time.

THE PLAYBOOK

2. The Manipulation Toolkit

Narcissistic abuse has a playbook, and it is close to the same playbook every time. Once you can name the tactic, it loses a great deal of its power over you.

Love bombing. Overwhelming affection, gifts, and talk of soulmates within weeks. It is not love. It is a hook.

Gaslighting. You are told it never happened, you remember it wrong, you are too sensitive. Over time you stop trusting your own mind.

Projection. Everything they are doing gets accused of you. The liar calls you a liar. The unfaithful one accuses you of unfaithfulness.

Blame shifting. Their rage, their job, their choices, their sin. Every problem they have becomes your fault, until you are the reason for everything.

DARVO. Deny, attack, and reverse victim and offender. You raise something they did, and within two minutes you are apologizing and they are the wounded one.

Silent treatment. Punishment dressed up as needing space. You are frozen out until you come back on their terms.

Hoovering. When you start pulling away, the charm comes back. Tears, promises, the person you first fell for. It lasts exactly as long as it takes to get you back.

Future faking. Promises of the thing you want most. The wedding, the move, the change, the counseling. It is always coming and it never arrives.

Triangulation. A third person is pulled in to compare you to, compete with, or report on you. You end up managing a relationship that is not yours.

Smear campaign. Your reputation is rewritten before you ever get to speak. By the time you tell your side, people have already been told what to think of you.

Reactive abuse and baiting. You are pushed until you finally snap, and then your reaction becomes the evidence that you were the problem all along.

Cruelty as a joke. The remark that cuts, followed by telling you that you cannot take a joke. It is contempt with an escape hatch attached.

THE AUDIENCE

3. Flying Monkeys

An abuser rarely works alone for long. Family, friends, coworkers, and sometimes church people get recruited to carry the message, apply pressure, report back on you, and tell you that you are overreacting.

Some of them know exactly what they are doing. Most have no idea they are being used. That distinction matters when you are deciding who is dangerous and who is simply deceived, but it does not change what you need to do in the moment. You do not owe anyone your story just because they came asking for it on someone else's behalf.

This is also where the smear campaign does its real work. The account of you that reaches people is not yours. Do not spend your strength trying to correct every version of it. The people who matter will watch your life over time and draw the right conclusion.

THE DEEPEST CUT

4. Spiritual Abuse

This is the one that does damage nothing else can reach, because it puts the abuse in YHWH's mouth. Scripture stops being bread and becomes a weapon.

Submission preached one direction. Verses about your role are quoted constantly. The verses about theirs are never mentioned.

Your walk used as leverage. If you do not do what they want, you are told you are not right with YHWH, you are rebellious, you are in sin, you need to pray more.

Prayer withheld. They will not pray with you, will not pray over the home, and then hold your spiritual life up as the thing that is lacking.

Forgiveness weaponized. You are told that forgiving means forgetting, staying quiet, and letting it continue. That is not forgiveness. That is a leash with a Bible verse on it.

Repentance performed. Tears and apologies arrive on schedule, especially when you get close to leaving. Nothing about the behavior changes afterward.

Leaders enlisted. Counsel is sought only where the story has already been told their way, so the correction always lands on you.

Hear this plainly. Shame that is manufactured by another person is not conviction from YHWH. Conviction is specific, it is aimed at something you actually did, and it leads you toward repentance and freedom. Manufactured shame is vague, it is aimed at who you are, and it leads you toward compliance. One sets you free. The other keeps you useful.

In the last days grievous times will come. For men will be lovers of self, lovers of money, boastful, arrogant, blasphemers, disobedient to parents, unthankful, unholy, without natural affection, unforgiving, slanderers, without self control, fierce, not lovers of good, traitors, headstrong, conceited, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, holding a form of godliness but having denied its power. Turn away from these also.

2 TIMOTHY 3:1 TO 5

CONFIDENCE BROKEN

5. What You Shared in Trust

Early on you were invited to open up. The childhood you survived. The mistakes you made before you knew better. The thing you had never told anyone. It felt like intimacy. For some people it is intimacy. For an abuser it is inventory.

Later, every one of those things comes back at you as ammunition. Your past is quoted to prove you cannot be trusted now. A mistake you repented of years ago is produced in the middle of an argument that has nothing to do with it. The wound you were most afraid to name is used to explain why your objection does not count.

There is a mark of the enemy on this one. Revelation calls him the accuser. Accusation is the constant recitation of what you have already been forgiven for. If someone in your life is doing that work full time, you are entitled to notice whose work it is.

There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Messiah Yahshua.

ROMANS 8:1

THE CRUELEST LEVERAGE

6. Using Children Against You

When the usual pressure stops working, the children become the pressure. It shows up in ways that are easy to deny and devastating to live under.

Threats about custody. You are told you will lose them, that no court will believe you, that you have nothing without them.

Children as messengers. They are sent to deliver what the adult will not say directly, or sent back to report what you said.

Turning them against you. Your character is worked on quietly, in the car, at bedtime, until your own child repeats a phrase that is not theirs.

The good parent performance. Sudden, visible involvement whenever there is an audience, and none at all when there is not.

Guilt through the children. Everything you consider doing for your own safety is reframed as something you would be doing to them.

If this is where you are, write things down. Dates, what was said, what was witnessed. Not to build a case against a person, but because your memory will be worked on and you will need something outside yourself that tells the truth. Keep it somewhere they cannot reach.

HOW IT GROWS

7. The Ladder and the Boiling Frog

It almost never starts loud. It escalates slowly, and the slowness is the point.

STAGE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
1	Small dismissals. You are too sensitive. You are imagining it.
2	Gaslighting. You are told it never happened.
3	Verbal abuse. Name calling, mocking, yelling meant to dominate.
4	Intimidation. Slammed doors, broken things, blocked exits.
5	Coercive control. Money, time, and decisions stop being yours.
6	Physical violence, or the threat of it.
7	The honeymoon reset. Tears, gifts, promises, and then it begins again.

That last stage is not repentance. That is the cycle catching its breath.

This is the boiling frog. A joke that stings. A phone that gets checked. A friend you slowly stop seeing. By the time it gets loud, your support system is already gone and your sense of normal has been quietly rewritten. That is why people on the outside ask why you did not leave at the beginning. There was no beginning. There was a hundred small beginnings, each one small enough to excuse.

THE STANDARD

8. What Scripture Says

Scripture does not instruct you to fix these people. It instructs you to guard yourself, and it names the behavior for what it is.

Now the deeds of the flesh are obvious, which are sexual immorality, uncleanness, lustfulness, idolatry, sorcery, hatred, strife, jealousies, outbursts of anger, rivalries, divisions, heresies, envy, murders, drunkenness, orgies, and things like these.

GALATIANS 5:19 TO 21

Keep your heart with all diligence, for out of it is the wellspring of life.

PROVERBS 4:23

There is no fear in love, but perfect love casts out fear, because fear has punishment.

1 JOHN 4:18

Have no fellowship with the unfruitful deeds of darkness, but rather even reprove them.

EPHESIANS 5:11

Read 1 John 4:18 again. Love and the fear of punishment cannot live in the same house. Whatever is producing that fear in you, it is not love.

And notice what 2 Timothy does after the list. It does not say fix them. It says turn away. Boundaries are not rebellion, and they are not a failure of faith. Boundaries protect what YHWH entrusted to you.

GETTING OUT

9. Leaving, and Where to Find Help

READ THIS PART CAREFULLY

The most dangerous moments are when you set a boundary, when you stand up, and when you get ready to leave. That is when the control feels threatened. Make a plan. Tell someone safe. Do not do it alone.

US National Domestic Violence Hotline. 1-800-799-7233, or text START to 88788. Free, confidential, available 24 hours a day. They will help you build a safety plan, and you do not have to be ready to leave to call them.

Celebrate Recovery. A Christ centered recovery program, and not only for addiction. Two thirds of the people in those rooms are there for something else: codependency, control issues, anxiety, depression, growing up in a broken home, and emotional, mental, physical, and sexual abuse. You do not register, you do not pay, and you do not have to tell anyone you are coming.

RESOURCE	WHERE TO FIND IT
Find a group	crlocator.com
Free weekly online meeting	celebraterecovery.com/weekly-online-recovery-meetings
Find your local CR representative	crgroups.info
Kingdom Life Study app	app.kingdom-life-ministry.com

One thing to hold on to. Celebrate Recovery is a healing community, not a safety plan. If you are still living in the house with an active abuser, the hotline comes first. CR is where the healing work happens once you are safe enough to do it.

And if you take nothing else from this: the shame you are carrying was handed to you. It was never yours. You can set it down.

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2 Timothy 3:1 to 5	The character described, and the instruction to turn away	Section 4
Proverbs 4:23	Guard your heart, for out of it is the wellspring of life	Section 8
1 John 4:18	Perfect love casts out fear, because fear has punishment	Section 8
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Romans 8:1	No condemnation for those in Messiah Yahshua	Section 5
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Psalms 34:18	YHWH is near to those who have a broken heart	Closing

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PSALM 34:18

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